

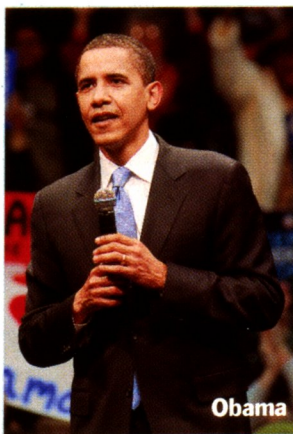
LOCOMOTIF S. PRASANNARAJAN

American Idol



Change. The word is as old as politics. It is the word that powers the narratives of revolutions and liberations. And we are no longer surprised by the trajectory of "change" in history: it begins as romance and ends as terror. And there are no stump speeches in modern times without "change". Now professional cynics are requested to stop frowning and take notice: the word has spawned a movement in America. A 46-year-old African-American freshman senator from Illinois with an air of the prophetic and with a vocabulary to match has set off a dream wave that continues to draw in the young, the beautiful, the affluent, the coloured and the angry. "We are the change that we see seek." "Yes, we can." His inspirational one-liners have already become hymns to the converts—and converts are multiplying, not only in primaries and caucuses and Hollywood but in the op-ed pages of conservatism as well. What is it that makes Barack Obama, who has now edged past Hillary Clinton in the Democratic primary race, a synonym for "change" and "hope"? Why does Obama make, as an excited British observer wrote, "the voters feel better about themselves?" His youthful charisma? His multicultural back story? His middle name? His colour? His intellect? His looks? His poetry? His "inexperience" in Washington? The audacity of his dream?

We may argue that Obamania is inevitable: in the life of nations, there comes a moment when the familiar is swept aside, when the idyll is shattered. In America, there were many such moments—



Kennedy, Reagan and, of course, Clinton. The next big moment has to be Obama. If not, it will be a huge letdown. Obamaniacs will feel orphaned and cheated by a soulless system. By the machine. So, it is not just about change; it is about changing with Obama. It is an electoral rite of passage. And it is made possible by another man of change—a president who has never been indulged by the media as a fairytale. George Bush, the most caricatured commander in chief, has changed America—and the world—more than any other President in recent history. Bush is all gauche idealism—no poetry, no phrases for the sake of history books, and no yearning to be liked by the commentariat. What the presidential primaries need is a Bush without Bushisms. That is why, when set against the experienced and the established, Obama looks and sounds the part—"the change that we seek".

RAVI S SAHANI



Losing to Gain

HYDERABAD Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) supremo K. Chandra Sekhara Rao's gambit to gain the confidence of large sections of the electorate with his party's campaign for separate state is poised to recoil. Rao has planned to force the resignation of all 16 MLAs and five MPs effective from March 6 in the fond hope that Congress President Sonia Gandhi and the UPA will announce firm plans for the carving out of Telangana from Andhra Pradesh.

Rao's gameplan is to create an opportunity to regain lost ground and send across the message that the people are for the new state by winning all the by-elections whenever they are held. Alleging that the Congress is the only obstacle, Rao has, in a veiled threat, warned the state Government that it will have to face serious consequences if the peaceful separatist movement takes an ugly turn. "Don't think that the people of Telangana have no guts," declares Rao as he

prepares to intensify the battle. The TRS chief is able to take the aggressive pitch largely because of the dilly dallying in the Congress with its own leaders speaking in discordant voices.

However, a tactful Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy is doing his best to negate Rao's claims, impressing upon Sonia that the so-called sentiments for a separate state are not as strong as portrayed by Rao. Further, Reddy's plan to allot 500-sq yard housing plots in a prime area of Hyderabad at a nominal cost to all 294 legislators and MPs is still in the works.

If the TRS legislators and MPs do finally carry out their threat and resign, they stand to lose the prime property worth upwards of Rs 1.50 crore. To add to their woes, it is also unclear whether the Election Commission will hold by-polls and no less certain are the prospects of the TRS in it. Evidently, Rao has put the TRS in a bind.

by Amarnath K. Menon